

recognized William's talents in this field. In 1912, he was accepted into Christ Church Cathedral School in Oxford, where he spent the next six years. It was at this choral school that he began composing.

His abilities gained him a place, aged only 16, as an undergraduate at Christ Church, a college of the University of Oxford. Although he excelled there at music, he neglected other academic subjects, repeatedly failed exams, and left the university without a degree in 1920. However, at Oxford he had become close friends with poets such as Siegfried Sassoon and Sacheverell Sitwell. The latter invited him to lodge in London with his siblings, Edith and Osbert. The Sitwells (see box) provided Walton with an attic in Chelsea where he could work, as well as an introduction to London society and its writers, artists, and composers.